

Ledger and Legend

The Business Lives of Famous Writers

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Chapter 3

Grand Designs: James Joyce's Money-Making Schemes

James Joyce spent most of his adult life short of money, and most of his letters home doubled as appeals for it. What is less often remarked on is how many different ways he tried to fix the problem himself, rather than simply asking. Between 1904 and 1922 alone he pursued schemes of a variety of kinds, including:

- Cultural-import ventures, meant to bring a foreign novelty to an under-served market — most famously, Dublin's first dedicated cinema.
- Speculative trading arrangements, meant to exploit a price gap between two cities — Irish tweed sold into a Central European market.
- Steady, unglamorous labor — private English lessons — that in fact outperformed every scheme built to replace it.
- Direct appeals to patrons, where the outcome depended less on business acumen than on one benefactor's continuing goodwill.

underline

Most biographers treat these episodes as color — amusing detours from the real work of writing *Dubliners*, *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*, and *Ulysses*. Read together, though, they form a fairly consistent portrait of a particular kind of financial temperament: quick to commit, slow to budget, and remarkably good at recruiting other people's capital.

Six Warning Signs of a Joyce Scheme

Looking across the ventures described in this chapter, a pattern emerges reliably enough that it is worth stating as a checklist. A given Joyce scheme tends to show most of the following six traits.

1. **The Confidence Principle.** Does the plan rest on Joyce's certainty that he alone has correctly read a market — Dublin's appetite for moving pictures, Trieste's appetite for Irish cloth — that has somehow escaped everyone already working in it?
2. **The Borrowed Capital Principle.** Is the money going in almost entirely someone else's: Triestine investors, family members, or a patron persuaded to advance funds against future royalties that do not yet exist?
3. **The Impatience Principle.** Is the venture expected to turn a profit within months, with no budget for the slow work of building a market, staff, or reputation?

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4. **The Delegation Principle.** Is day-to-day management handed to a relative, a partner, or a local agent, while Joyce himself remains occupied with writing, teaching, or travel?
5. **The Exit Principle.** When the numbers turn bad, is the response to sell out quickly — often at a loss — rather than to adjust the plan and continue?
6. **The Relapse Principle.** Within a year or two, does a new scheme appear, built on the same confidence and the same unwillingness to budget for slow returns?

Example 1: The Cinema Volta

In 1909, Joyce was living in Trieste, where he had noticed that dedicated cinemas — a novelty Dublin still lacked — were doing brisk business. He proposed to a group of Triestine businessmen that they back a Dublin cinema, with himself as the local partner who understood the city. The Volta opened on Mary Street in December 1909, showing a programme of continental short films.¹

The Confidence Principle, Applied

Joyce's pitch to his backers was that he, uniquely, understood both what European audiences already loved and what Dubliners were ready for. In practice, the programming leaned heavily on Trieste's taste rather than Dublin's, and the novelty of moving pictures alone was not enough to hold an audience once two rival cinemas opened nearby within the year.



The Delegation Principle, Applied

Joyce helped select the premises and negotiate the opening programme, then returned to Trieste within weeks, leaving the day-to-day running of the cinema to the Triestine partners and a local manager. Decisions about pricing and scheduling were made without him, by people with no particular feel for the Dublin market he had claimed to understand.

The Exit Principle, Applied

By the summer of 1910, the Volta was losing money steadily enough that the Triestine backers sold the cinema — at a loss — to an English company that already operated a chain of picture houses. Joyce's own stake, modest to begin with, returned little.² The building continued to show films for decades afterward, under management with no connection to Joyce at all.



■ Weaver's patronage ■ Private tutoring ■ Journalism & royalties ■ Ventures & speculation

Figure 3.1. Approximate sources of Joyce's income, 1917–1930. Patronage — not any of his own ventures — was consistently the largest share.

Example 2: The Tweed Concession

Around the same period, Joyce pursued a second, quieter scheme: an exclusive agency to sell Irish tweed and poplin in Trieste. He arranged samples from Dublin manufacturers and enlisted family members to help manage the correspondence and local sales, on the theory that Central European buyers would pay a premium for genuine Irish cloth that no competitor was yet importing.

The Borrowed Capital Principle, Applied

The samples, the shipping, and the initial advertising were financed on credit extended by the Dublin mills themselves, who were promised payment once Trieste orders came in — a structure that left Joyce with almost no capital of his own at risk, and the mills carrying most of it.

The Relapse Principle, Applied

Sales were modest and uneven, and the concession quietly wound down within a few years — not with a dramatic collapse like the Volta, but simply fading as Joyce’s attention moved elsewhere. Within a comparable stretch of years, a new scheme would reliably appear: an appeal for a government grant, a proposal to a newspaper, or a request that a friend advance funds against a book not yet finished.³

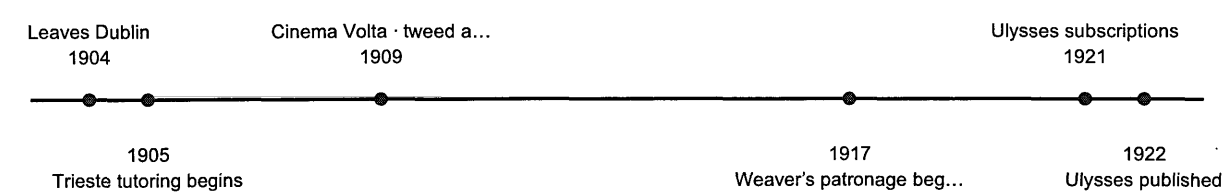


Figure 3.2. A rough timeline of Joyce’s ventures against the two steadier income sources — tutoring and patronage — that framed them.

Comparing the Ventures

Table 3.1 lines up six episodes from Joyce’s financial life, from the earliest tutoring work through the subscription drive that eventually funded Ulysses. The pattern holds fairly well: the entries that behave like classic “schemes” — short-lived, dependent on someone else’s money, quickly abandoned — sit alongside two entries, tutoring and patronage, that do not fit the pattern at all, and that quietly kept everything else afloat.

Table 3.1. Six episodes from Joyce’s financial life, compared.

Venture	City & years	Backers / capital	Outcome
Private English tutoring	Trieste & Zurich, 1905–1920	Fees from individual pupils	Modest but reliable; the single steadiest income of Joyce’s European years.

Table 3.1. Six episodes from Joyce's financial life, compared. (continued)

Venture	City & years	Backers / capital	Outcome
Cinema Volta	Dublin, 1909–1910	Four Triestine investors	Opened Dec. 1909; sold at a loss to an English chain within a year.
Tweed & poplin concession	Trieste, 1909–1912	Credit from Dublin mills; family agents	Modest, uneven sales; wound down quietly rather than collapsing.
Harriet Shaw Weaver's patronage	London, 1917–1930	Weaver's personal fortune, incl. a trust settlement	By far the largest and steadiest source of support in Joyce's later years.
Eye-surgery fund appeals	Zurich & Paris, 1917–1923	Ad hoc gifts and loans from friends and patrons	Recurring rather than resolved; a new appeal followed nearly every operation.
Ulysses serialization & subscriptions	New York & Paris, 1918–1922	The Little Review; Shakespeare and Company subscribers	Eventually profitable, but preceded by an obscenity prosecution and heavy legal costs.

Two lessons stand out. First, the ventures Joyce actively designed and ran — the cinema, the tweed agency — underperformed the arrangements he simply maintained, tutoring and, later, Weaver's patronage. Second, the single most consequential piece of "fundraising" in his career, the subscription drive for *Ulysses*, succeeded precisely because it was run by someone else — Sylvia Beach — with the discipline Joyce's own schemes generally lacked.

What These Schemes Teach Us

None of this diminishes the writing. If anything, it clarifies how the writing got made: not by a self-sufficient literary business, but by a household that ran on patronage, tutoring, and a fairly constant trickle of speculative side ventures, most of which lost money. A few points are worth carrying forward:

- Put a premium on the arrangement that has already proven itself. Tutoring outlasted every scheme meant to replace it, precisely because it required no capital and no market-timing.
- Borrowed capital changes incentives. Because the tweed venture and the cinema were financed mostly with other people's money, Joyce had less at stake in making either succeed than his backers did.
- A single steady patron can outweigh a dozen small ventures. Weaver's support did more for Joyce's finances than the Volta, the tweed agency, and every minor appeal put together.

- Delegated execution, run by someone with real discipline — as with Beach's handling of the *Ulysses* subscriptions — succeeded where Joyce's own hands-on ventures did not.

As you read the letters and biographies covering this period, it is worth asking, of any new scheme that appears, which of the six warning signs above it shows — and which of the two things that actually worked, steady labor or a steady patron, it is quietly standing in for.

Notes

1. Richard Ellmann, *James Joyce*, rev. ed. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1982), 300–305, on the founding of the Cinema Volta and Joyce's Trieste backers.
2. Ellmann, *James Joyce*, 305–308, on the sale of the Volta within a year of its opening.
3. Stanislaus Joyce, *My Brother's Keeper*, ed. Richard Ellmann (New York: Viking Press, 1958), on the family's recurring role financing and managing James Joyce's ventures.
4. *Letters of James Joyce*, ed. Richard Ellmann, vol. 2 (New York: Viking Press, 1966), on the tweed and poplin correspondence with Dublin manufacturers.
5. Jane Lidderdale and Mary Nicholson, *Dear Miss Weaver: Harriet Shaw Weaver, 1876–1961* (New York: Viking Press, 1970), on the scale and duration of Weaver's patronage.
6. Kevin Birmingham, *The Most Dangerous Book: The Battle for James Joyce's Ulysses* (New York: Penguin Press, 2014), on the Little Review prosecution and the Paris subscription drive for *Ulysses*.